

OPSC6311 POE PART

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**Members : Oratile Maungwa(ST10443081) | Gontse
Rakosa (ST10449265) | Kunwe Tyrone
Mdaka(ST10262122) | Richard Ernest
Sebola(ST10441486)**

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Introduction

This study's goal is to examine three current Android-based personal budgeting apps. The goal of this investigation is to find creative design elements, industry-standard functionality, and possible gamification techniques that might be used in the creation of a brand-new, captivating **Personal Budget Tracker app. You Need A Budget (YNAB)**, which promotes a proactive, **zero-based budgeting philosophy**; **Goodbudget**, which **digitises the conventional envelope budgeting system**; and **Credit Karma**, which **combines budgeting with more comprehensive financial health monitoring**, are some of the popular approaches in personal finance management that are represented by the chosen applications (John Marshall Bank, 2026).

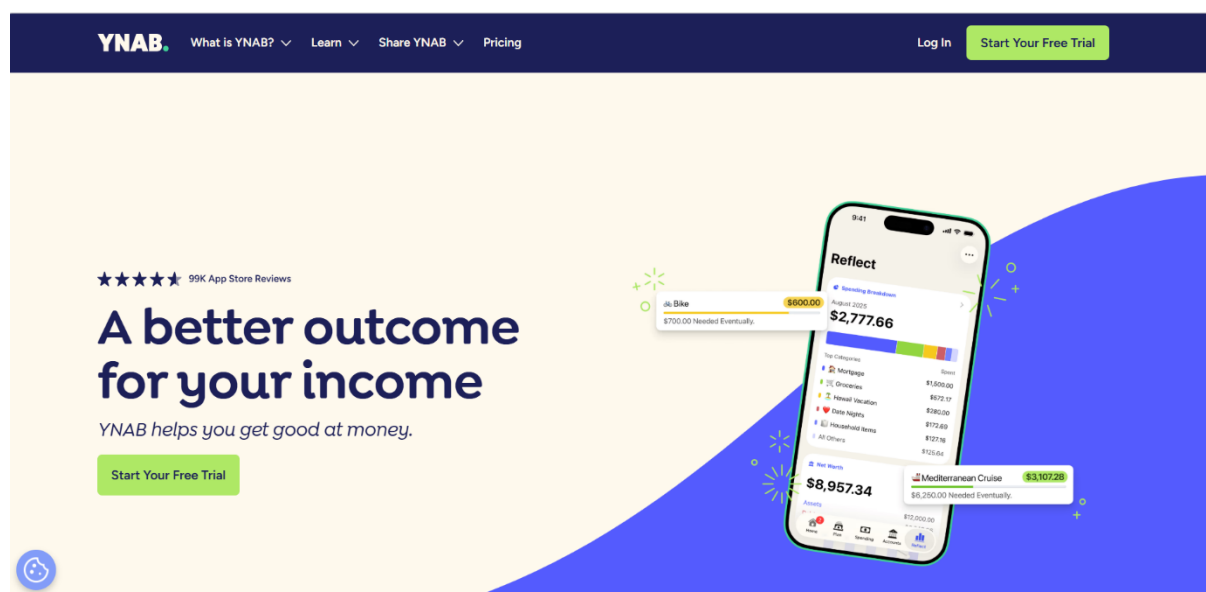
Research on existing budget apps

App 1: You Need a Budget(YNAB)

Overview of YNAB

YNAB, or You Need A Budget, is a **high-end budgeting program** that sets itself apart by strictly adhering to the zero-based budgeting approach. The fundamental idea is to "give every dollar a job," which means that users allocate all of their monthly income to **debt repayment, savings targets, or particular categories** of expenses until their income less costs equals zero (Luthi, 2026). Although YNAB **promotes active, manual budgeting, it automatically imports transactions by syncing with users' bank accounts**. The "Four Rules": Give Every Dollar a Job, Embrace Your True Expenses, Roll With the Punches, and Age Your Money are the foundation of the app's ideology (The CFO Club, 2026). It is accessible on iOS and Android, and there is a desktop browser version.

Screenshots of YNAB Main Budget Screen:



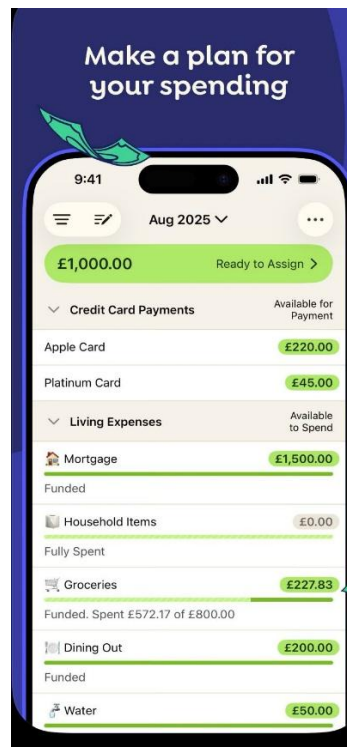
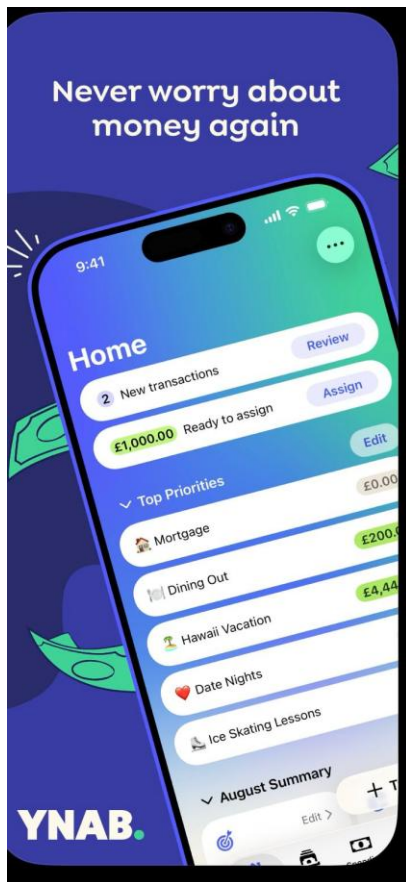


Image Description: Screenshots indicating or rather showing a clean -green themed interface showing a list of features and budgeting lists

Strengths and Weaknesses

Strengths:

- **Proactive Financial Control:** YNAB's approach is its best feature. It helps avoid **financial surprises and promotes long-term thinking** by requiring users to budget for all expenses, including random, non-monthly invoices ("True Expenses") (Luthi, 2026).
- **Educational Value:** The app's wealth of teaching materials, **such as live workshops, manuals, and podcasts, aid users in understanding and sticking to its budgeting concept** (The CFO Club, 2026).
- **Goal Tracking and Reporting:** YNAB has complete reporting capabilities that let users see their financial success, such as **precise spending breakdowns and net worth tracking over time** (Luthi, 2026).
- **Accountability and Syncing:** It's a great tool for couples and families to manage their finances together because it can share a budget with up to **five users and sync in real time across devices** (The CFO Club, 2026).

Weaknesses

- **Cost:** YNAB is one of the priciest budgeting programs available. It **costs \$14.99 a month or \$109 a year for a subscription**, and it only offers a 34-day trial instead of a free, permanently supported version (Luthi, 2026).
- **Steep Learning Curve:** Not everyone finds the zero-based budgeting approach to be instantly obvious. For individuals looking for a straightforward, hands-off tool, the **Four Rules** might be intimidating because **they frequently need a substantial learning curve** to comprehend and **regularly implement** (The CFO Club, 2026).
- **Manual Oversight Needed:** The app needs to be actively managed even with bank syncing. It can take some time for users to **approve, classify, and actively transfer money between categories** (Luthi, 2026).
- **No Bill Pay Feature:** YNAB's primary focus is on budgeting; it **lacks native bill management and bill pay capabilities**, so users must take care of those things on their own (The CFO Club, 2026).

Innovative Features

The "**Age of Money**" measure is YNAB's most innovative feature. This determines how **long your money typically stays in your bank account before being spent**. The objective is to **raise this age ideally to 30 days or longer to indicate that you are subsisting on funds from a prior month**, so ending the cycle of living pay cheque to pay cheque (Luthi, 2026). This is a strong, easy-to-understand gamification component that motivates users to accumulate savings and a safety net. Its **methodical handling of "True Expenses," which encourages users to set aside a small amount each month for yearly or irregular costs (such as auto insurance or holiday gifts)**, is another creative feature. **It turns potentially stressful large bills into manageable monthly savings goals** (The CFO Club, 2026).

App 2: Good Budget

Overview of Good Budget

The traditional "**envelope budgeting**" method is brought into the **digital era by the personal finance app Goodbudget**. Users of this method split their monthly money into virtual "envelopes" for several kinds of expenses, **like grocery, eating out, and entertainment** (WalletHub, 2025). At the beginning of each month, funds are allotted to these envelopes, and expenditures are monitored by keeping track of transactions and subtracting them from the appropriate envelope. The program **is primarily made for manual transaction entry, which encourages conscious spending**, even though its premium edition allows bank syncing (Chrome-Stats, 2026). With a heavy emphasis on syncing budgets across several devices for families or partners, **it is accessible on Android, iOS, and the web**.

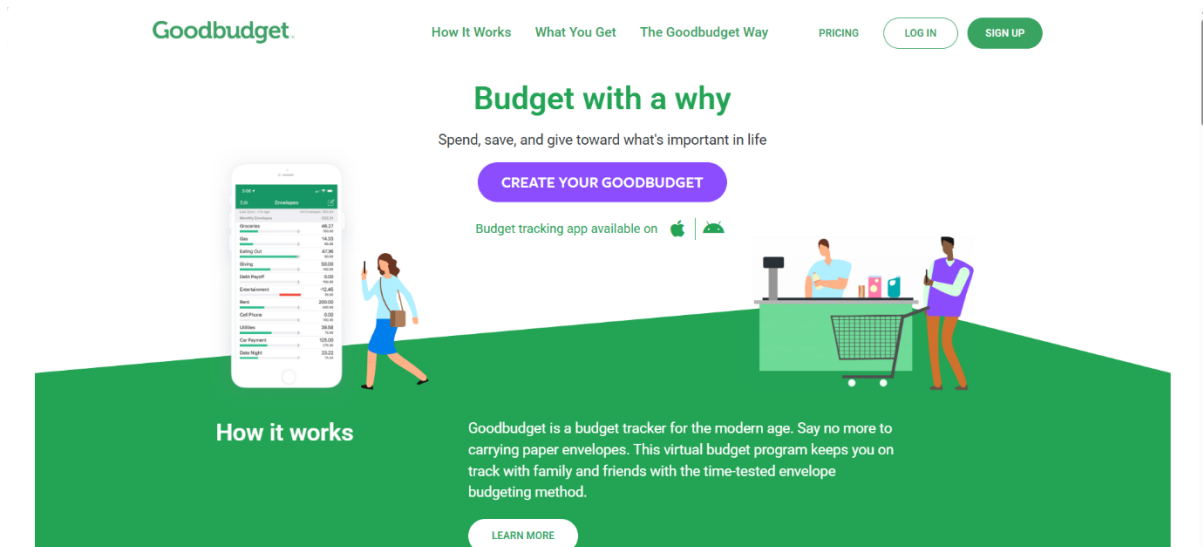


Image Description: Screenshots showing the visual interfaces showing coloured envelopes and categories to track spending like on rent, groceries and other expenses

Strengths and Weaknesses

Strengths:

- **Easy to Understand and Put into Practice:** The envelope method is a straightforward concept. It is quite successful at **preventing overspending** because it offers a **clear, visual depiction** of the money that is available in each category (WalletHub, 2026).

- **Free Plan Availability:** Individuals and couples on a tight budget can utilise Goodbudget's generous free plan, which enables users to create up to **20 envelopes and track their budget on two devices** (WalletHub, 2025).
- **Cross-Platform Syncing:** The software is a potent tool for household collaboration because it is excellent at maintaining **real-time budget synchronisation** across several phones and the web (Chrome-Stats, 2026).
- **Privacy-Focused Approach:** It attracts to people who have serious **privacy concerns** because it is based on manual entry and does not need users to link sensitive bank accounts (WalletHub, 2025).

Weaknesses:

- **Lack of Automation:** Using manual entry has drawbacks. Compared to programs that automatically **import and classify transactions**, this is a major disadvantage for consumers who want a "set and forget" solution (WalletHub, 2026).
- **Dated and Clunky User Interface (UI):** Several user evaluations and professional analyses indicate that Goodbudget's **UI feels antiquated and lacks the refinement and ease of use of its rivals**. The whole user experience may suffer as a result (WalletHub, 2025).
- **Limited Bank Integration:** According to reports, bank syncing, which is exclusive to the premium plan, has **limited capabilities and can be inconsistent, frequently failing to connect to specific** financial institutions (WalletHub, 2025).
- **No warnings or Reminders:** For forgetful users, the **app's absence of proactive functionality like bill reminders or warnings** when a budget envelope is running low might be a major disadvantage (WalletHub, 2026).

Innovative Features

Goodbudget's feature is found in its perfect implementation of the digital envelope **system for home participation, despite its conceptual simplicity**. The **dynamics of a shared household budget are accurately replicated by allowing several users to have individual logins (on the premium plan)** while contributing to and drawing from common "envelopes" (Chrome-Stats, 2026). Another **ingenious addition is its hashtag feature, which lets users tag transactions for more detailed tracking across categories**. Adding **#pet** to a **"Groceries" transaction for dog food**, for instance, enables a user to later track the total amount spent on their pet explicitly, adding a layer of personalised reporting without requiring complicated setup (WalletHub, 2025).

App 3: Credit karma

Overview of Credit Karma

From a straightforward **credit score app** to a powerful **personal finance tool**, Credit Karma **has developed into a comprehensive financial platform**. It has included more **potent budgeting and expenditure tracking capabilities**, but it is best known for offering **free access to credit scores and reports from TransUnion and Equifax** (John Marshall Bank, 2026). In order to give users a real-time overview of their spending, classify transactions, and monitor their net worth, the app immediately **coordinates with their bank and credit card accounts**. Its capabilities are intended to support its primary goal of assisting users in comprehending and enhancing their entire financial wellness, in contrast to specialised budgeting apps (Fondo, 2026). It is available on **Android and iOS**



The screenshot shows the Credit Karma website interface. At the top, there's a dark blue header with a navigation bar including links to Intuit, TurboTax, Credit Karma, QuickBooks, and Mailchimp. Below this is a main navigation bar with categories like Credit Cards, Personal Loans, Auto, Home, Money, Net Worth, Tax, Credit Scores, and Resources. The central banner features a woman looking thoughtful, with a callout box for 'Andrew, Tax Expert, 16 yrs' and a 'Powered by TurboTax' logo. The text on the banner reads: 'Confidence from a tax pro, so you feel like one. File as soon as today with a Full Service expert,* then get unlimited tax help all year round at no additional cost.*' There are 'Sign up' and 'Log in' buttons.

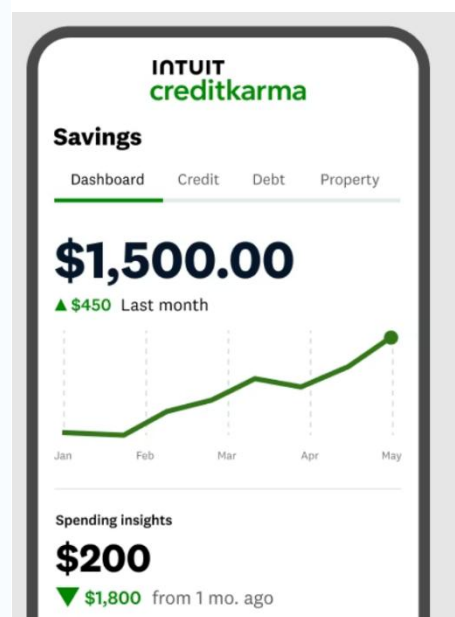
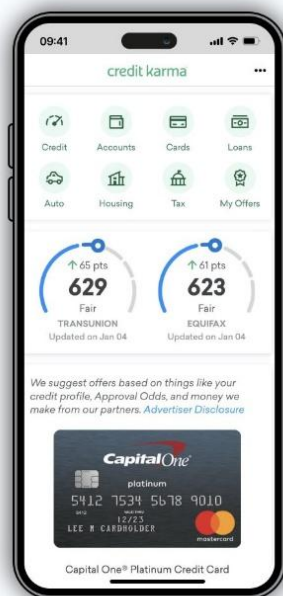


Image Description : Screenshots illustrating a dashboard with display of user credit score at the top and some other features or options on the interface and 'Savings' category outlining the amounts

Strengths and weaknesses:

Strengths:

- **Completely Free:** Credit Karma provides all of its functions, such as net worth tracking, budgeting tools, and credit monitoring, at no cost to the user (John Marshall Bank, 2026).
- **Holistic Financial Picture:** It gives customers a special and useful holistic perspective of their financial health by combining budgeting with credit score monitoring. Users can understand how their credit score may be affected by their spending patterns (such as credit utilisation) (John Marshall Bank, 2026).
- **Real-Time Syncing and trends:** Users can easily monitor where their money is moving over a user-selected period of time thanks to the app's simple, user-friendly dashboard with real-time spending statistics and visual trends (Fondo, 2026).
- **Personalised Insights and Alerts:** The app adds a layer of intelligent financial management by proactively sending notifications for odd expenditure, impending payments, and possible savings on financial items (WalletHub, 2026).

Weaknesses:

- **Ad-Supported Model:** The app's UI features financial product **recommendations and adverts since it is a free service**. The constant cross-selling of credit cards and loans within a budgeting application may be annoying to some users, even though it is usually not obtrusive (Fondo, 2026).
- **Less Proactive Budgeting:** Credit Karma's budgeting tools are more **analytical and reactive than those of YNAB or Goodbudget**. They are very good at keeping track of where money is going, but they don't do much to assist users in making plans before they spend it (WalletHub, 2026).
- **Data Usage Concerns:** **Some consumers may be concerned about how their data is used to target offers and recommendations**, much like with any free service that aggregates sensitive financial data (John Marshall Bank, 2026).

Innovative Features

The **smooth integration of budgeting with credit score and report monitoring is Credit Karma's most inventive feature**. For instance, its "**Credit Score Simulator**" lets users examine how possible financial choices, such as taking out a loan or paying off a credit card, can affect their credit score (John Marshall Bank, 2026). This is immediately influenced by budgeting data, which makes the relationship between daily expenditure and long-term credit health concrete and clear. Its "Salary" and "Job

Listings" integration, which displays local positions and compares salaries to those in comparable roles, is another noteworthy feature that gives financial planning a distinct income-focused aspect (WalletHub, 2026).

Visual Comparison of all three apps

Visual Comparison of All Three Apps			
	 You Need A Budget (YNAB)	 Goodbudget	 Credit Karma
Core Methodology	Zero-Based Budgeting "Give every rand/dollar a job"	Envelope Budgeting "Digital envelopes"	Spending Tracking & Credit Monitoring
Cost	\$14,99/month or \$109/year	Free (Basic) or \$10/month Premium	Completely Free (Ad-Supported)
Bank Syncing	Automatic Sync	Limited Sync (Premium)	Automatic Sync
Transaction Entry	Automatic + Manual Approval	Primarily Manual	Automatic Import
Best For	Full Control Users	Couples & Families	Free-Spending Trackers
Key Strength	Powerful & Educational	Simple & Collaborative	Free & Credit Scores
Key Weakness	High Cost & Learning Curve	Dated UI & Limited Sync	Reactive & Ad-Supported
Innovative Feature			
 Age of Money Build a Financial Buffer  Shared Digital Envelopes Multiple Logins  Credit Score Simulator Linked to Spending Habits			

(Canva Pty Ltd, 2026)

List of best features for our App :

The research indicates that the following features are best-in-class and ought to be given top priority when it comes to the new Personal Budget Tracker app:

Proactive Budgeting with Goals (Inspired by YNAB): In addition to tracking past expenditure, the software will enable users to create financial goals. This will include tools to break down irregular, "true" expenses into manageable monthly goals in order to save for them (Luthi, 2026).

Visual Spending Trends and Dashboards (Inspired by Credit Karma and YNAB): Clear, visual graphs and reports that display spending by category across user-selected time periods will be included in the app (Fondo, 2026). This enables consumers to recognise patterns and make wise choices. A progress dashboard that compares actuals to budget is crucial.

Gamification with Meaningful Metrics (Inspired by YNAB's "Age of Money"): Gamification components need to be connected to actual financial well-being. Users will be rewarded with digital badges for reaching savings milestones using a feature akin to "Days of Financial Freedom" that tracks how many days' worth of spending they have saved (The CFO Club, 2026). As a result, the abstract idea of saving becomes more concrete and interesting.

Simple, Collaborative Interface (Inspired by Goodbudget): The user interface ought to be clear and easy to use. Future features that enable household collaboration, such as the ability for multiple users to contribute to shared budget categories (such "Household Groceries"), should be considered while designing the app (Chrome-Stats, 2026).

Conclusion :

This study of YNAB, Goodbudget, and Credit Karma has given us important new information on the state of Android budgeting apps. Goodbudget's straightforward, collaborative, and visual envelope budgeting (WalletHub, 2025); Credit Karma's comprehensive, free integration of spending with credit health (John Marshall Bank, 2026); and YNAB's potent, methodology-driven system for proactive control (Luthi, 2026). A clear path for a new, captivating Personal Budget Tracker app has been built by combining the most successful components from previous apps: proactive goal setting, meaningful gamification, clear visualisations, and intuitive design.

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